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AMRIT LAL

Census Practices and Population Statistics of Kuomintang China (1911-1949) (*)

中华民国的人口调查
及
人口统计
(一九一一—一九四九)

SOURCES OF DATA: The main reservoir from which flow the population statistics pertaining to Kuomintang China (1911-1949) consist of the following channels:

a) Population censuses, notably the census of 1928.

b) Various registrations and investigations by Kmt. government.

c) The estimates of individual scholars and voluntary agencies.

Consideration can be first given to population censuses because of their grotesque application.

(*) Evaluation of source material is the beginning of analysis. The sources of material are many, and each of them has its peculiar advantages and disadvantages. This holds good for different methods of analysis and evaluation of data.

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The Censuses

The first census of the Kmt. period was the one conducted in 1912. This was virtually an extension of the census 1909-11 which the last Manchu Emperor had ordered as a reform measure to set up the base for the establishment of constitutional monarchy in the country. But before the census data was surfaced, the king had abdicated and the final totals were received by the new republic. The new government, however, ordered for its own census of people as a basis for election of representatives of national parliament. This called for the creation of an elaborate network of statistical system on a national scale. The implementation of the ideal was, however, delayed because a number of regional war-lord governments were either beyond the control of or openly defied the nominal government at Nanking.

Before the close of 1927, the *Nei-cheng puh* or Ministry of Interior, which superseded the Ministry of Home Affairs of 1906-27, had already notified the civil affairs departments of provinces that the population of the entire country was to be censused. The provinces were twice instructed to carry out census operation. In 1927, census was ordered to be conducted in Kiangsu, Chekiang and Anhwei. In 1928, census was ordered in other provinces. This demanded totals by sex by the local census offices for each of these items :

> " persons present, persons temporarily absent, number gainfully occupied, school-going-age children between 6 and 12 years of age, men between 20 and 40 years of age, number of persons previously convicted, number of suspicious persons, number of invalids, number of unrelated persons living together, and the number of Buddhists, Taoists, Mohammedans, Protestants, Catholics, and all other religious denominations ".

To enter the data seven forms were designed and a registration system introduced. Four of these forms were to be used where local self government had been established and the remaining three were designed to secure current day-to-day information of vital events. Detailed tabulations were to be made for each

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hsien. Local governments were to send their respective compilations to the departments of Civil Affairs in the provincial governments for onward transmission to the Ministry of Interior at the Centre. Such a grand design of registration was the original intention of the census planners.

The attempt to count the Chinese in this way was an abortive one. By Dec. 1930, complete returns had been received from 13 provinces, partial returns from 3 others, and up to the summer of 1931, 12 provinces were still wanting to submit their tallies. The Ministry's reported total of 474,787,386 was obviously based on estimates for the provinces which failed to report, and was subsequently revised by the Directorate of Statistics and by demographers outside China. To quote, in this context, from the report of the Ministry of Interior :

> " . . . all kinds of accidents, famines and disasters one after another, poor transportation, and other reasons prevented the compilation of the investigation and made it poor in quality. Our household statistics were always reported by *hsien* governments. They have always been unreliable. After the Republic of China was established, we began actual investigations. However, the local officials cannot understand the meaning of the work. In addition, military action occured every year. Therefore the results of the investigations were not very good " (1).

Another salient point of the census 1928 was its reliance upon police as a source of census data in large cities, and in the rural areas through the age-long system of Pao-Chia in which data were largely taken from defective registers. The government preoccupation about this time was " how to keep track of every individual in the country so as to be called up for military service, tax him, or apprehend him if a criminal ". To this end, there were in the census forms, several peculiar questions relating to suspicious or previously convicted persons which bear no semblance to the conventional census schedules of other countries.

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(1) REPUBLIC OF CHINA. MINISTRY OF INTERIOR, DEPARTMENT OF STATISTICS : *Statistical Report on Household Investigation in Various Provinces and Municipalities*, 1928, Nanking, 1931.

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The absence of census consciousness may have also provoked defective returns. For example, people nursed the following prejudices against census operations :

> " There was a rumor in the country that the governement was going to tax every person five cents and was going to use the census as a basis of selection of soldiers " (1).

> " The names and dates of births when written on a piece of paper which is then burned near a bridge or a house, may not only fortify its structure but may also produce the death of the child " (2).

Some writers on the subject are of the view that there was considerable underreporting of the children in the census 1928 (3), while many of the provincial reports were simply revisions of earlier estimates. The final series of provincial population seems reasonable in that the 1928 populations were far below those for 1850 in the provinces which were disturbed by Taiping rebellion (table I A), far above those for 1850 in most other areas (table II B).

During the period between 1930 and 1947 many sporadic efforts were made to conduct censuses in different parts of the country. Jaffe (1947) (4) mentions some twelve such attempts. For all the twelve censuses age distribution of both sexes is available, for seven of them distribution by age and sex are available.

War with Japan broke out in 1930 which climaxed with the onset of Second World War. Japan occupied Manchuria and many other parts of China. When the war ended in 1945, Civil War between communists and nationalists plagued the country. These events hampered the conducting of another

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(1) CHEN, D.T., CHIAO, C.A. & THOMPSON, W.S., *An Experiment in the Registration of Vital Statistics in China*, Scripps Foundation for Research in Population Problems, 1938.

(2) LIU, NANMING, *Contribution à l'etude de la pop. Chinoise*, Geneva, 1936. Biot. Jour. Asiatique, ser. 3, vol. I, II & V.

(3) This is also the view of CHIAO, C.M., *A Study on Chinese Population*, Milbank Memorial Fund Quartely, vol. XI, 1933.

(4) JAFFE, A.J., *A note on the growth of Chinese Population*, Human Biology, vol. 19, Febr. 1947.

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TABLE I A

Provincial Populations of Some Provinces (1850-1928)

PROVINCES (including cities) By Regions	1850 (000)	1928 (000)
Shantung	33,127	28,672
Shansi	15,131	12,228
Kansu	15,437	6,281
Kiangsu	44,175	34,126
Anhwei	37,611	21,715
Chekiang	30,027	20,643
Hupeh	33,738	26,699
Kiangsi	24,515	20,323

Source: Abstracted from a paper, *Questions on Population Growth in China*, contributed by Irene B. Taeuber & Nai-Chi Wang to Milbank Memorial Fund, Proceedings of the 36th. Annual Conference held Nov. 4-5, 1959, at the Carnegie Endowment International Centre.

TABLE I B

Provincial Populations of Some Provinces (1850-1928)

PROVINCES (including cities) By regions	1850 (000)	1928 (000)
Hopeh	23,401	31,232
Honan	23,927	30,566
Hunan	20,614	31,501
Kwangsi	7,827	13,648
Kweichow	5,434	14,746
Yunnan	7,376	13,821

Source: Same as for table I A.

nation-wide census for at least two decades. It was not before 1947 that Pao Hui-tseng (1), Director of Census Department, hinted the possibility of another census in 1950 on modern census lines and gave the assurance that the census would be repeated

(1) BOEHRINGER, C.H., *Official Estimates of Population of China including the Areas Under the Control of the Chinese Communists.* American Embassy Reports, Nanking, 13 March, 1947, n. 95.

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after every ten years. But, again, with the evaporation of Kmt. government in 1949, this grand design of decennial censuses and the proposal to take census in 1950 could not grow beyond the germinating stage.

Investigations & Registrations by Kuomintang Government

The Pao-Chia system which had been the only source of population registration during Ch'ing dynasty was abolished in 1902 and police system was saddled in its place. But in 1934 Pao-Chia system once again attracted the fancy of Chiang Kai -Shek and became an important instrument of population registration till the establishment of communist government in mainland China.

The Pao-Chia system divided the nation into small groups of families, making each group collectively responsible for the crimes of its members, for the behaviour of its strangers and guests and for supplying soldiers to armies at the time of need. These features of registration might have told upon the efficiency of the system and gave rise to a substantial amount of under-reporting.

In 1946 and 1947 there were investigations and registrations of the population in many provinces on a limited scale which yelded only partial tabulations and defective returns. In fact, there were multiple record systems which were unrelated with one-another. For example, four agencies had been put up on the job of collecting and compiling population data. According to a law passed in 1941, household investigations were under the charge of the Bureau of Budgets, Statistics and Accounts. The Ministry of Interior conducted household registration on the basis of a law passed as early as in 1931. The police was responsible for household investigations particularly in the cities while Pao-Chia household records came under the duties of local self government organization.

In 1946, however, the Nationalist Government, dissatisfied with the multiplicity of bodies in the realm of population registration, passed the Household Registration Law which aimed at consolidating all household registration in newly established

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Household Registration Administrative Officer under the Ministry of Interior. This meant a renovation of the entire set-up of Pao-Chia machinery and investigation of households. The final job was the formation of registers. Thereafter, monthly reports on gross changes in population were to be combined with annual reports on population by residence, age, marital status, occupation, and education (1).

The composition of the population in quinquennial age groups and sex reveals major deficits of women and children, together with a large incidence of irregularities in age reporting of men, particularly that of men in and around military ages. In other words the reported population total of 456 million (1946) and 463 million (1947) were understatements of what might have been the actual population. This impression is further reinforced by the Chinese official estimates of population, which were made on the basis of data lacking in uniformity in method of collection. The Chinese Year Book, 1944-45 (p. 73), for example, gives the following series :

TABLE II

Growth of Population, 1912-1944

YEAR	POPULATION	SOURCE OF DATA
1912	405,810,067	Ministry of Interior
1923	441.849,148	id.
1933	444,436,557	Bureau of Statistics
1936	479,084,651	Ministry of Interior
1944 *	464,924,584	Bureau of Statistics

* For the year 1948, U. N. 's Statistical Year Book (1954) gives a population of 463.5 million.

N. B. The table is preceded by the statement : " Although the methods of collecting data by various provinces and municipalities in different periods are not uniform,a comparison of these figures will certainly give some idea of the main trends of population changes in China ".

(1) This information was compiled for only 12 provinces and 6 cities in the first half of 1947. CHINA REPUBLIC, MINISTRY OF INTERIOR, BUREAU OF CENSUS : *National Household Statistics For July-December, 1947, with Static Population Statistics for 18 Provinces and Municipalities*, Nanking, 1948.

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George Cressey (1955) in an epoch making volume " Land of the 500 Million " mentions a few other estimates made on the basis of various investigations and registrations by government agencies during this period. The figures quoted by him as well as the sources from where quoted, make an interesting departure from the series quoted in the table II above. Against the population figure of 444.4 million for the year 1933, for example, following figures are quoted :

TABLE III

Population Figures, 1928-31

YEAR	POPULATION (million)	SOURCE	REMARKS
1928-29 . . .	485.0	Post Offices	Excluding Mongolia
1930	444.0	Maritime customs	18 provinces & Manchuria
1931	485.0	Ministry of Interior	

ESTIMATES OF INDIVIDUAL SCHOLARS

The most notable attempt to count the Chinese people which deserves mention is the one made by Buck (1937) (1). From his studies of rural population of China it would appear that the total may touch 600 million. While his survey provides no actual enumeration of population, he shows on an average farm population in the eight agricultural regions studied, 1,485 persons per square mile of cultivated land. As there were some 340,000 square miles of cultivated land in the 22 provinces studied, we might conclude, as Buck reasoned, that there were 504,900,000 rural people in rural sector alone, to which he added the population of the north-eastern provinces.

Some other estimates made by scholars for this period, which are at extreme variations from one another, are laid in the table IV below :

(1) BUCK, J.L., *Land Utilization in China*, 1937.

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TABLE IV

Population Estimates for a Few Selected Dates of Kuomintang Period

YEAR	AUTHORITY	POP. IN MILLION	REMARKS
1912	Thompson & Chen	370.2	Cited by George B. Cressey: Asia's Lands & Peoples (1963, 3rd. Edn.)
1920	Wilcox, Walter F.	397.4	Studies in American Demography
1928-29. . . .	Liu Nan Ming	408.5	From the reference at f. n. 2. p. 304 of this paper
1930	D. K. Lieu	470–480	Milbank Memorial Fund (Qtr.), Octb. 1933
1930	M. T. Z. Tyau	463	Cited by George B. Cressey: Land of 500 Million (1955)
1930	Chang heng Chen	480	Milbank Memorial Fund (Qtr.), Octb. 1933
1937	Wilcox, Walter F.	450	Studies in American Demography

N. B. For the period 1930-50 any figure in the vicinity of 450 million was considered to be sufficently representative because there was no way to refute it.

AN APPRAISAL

The 37 years (1911-1949) of the Kuomintang Government in China has come to be dubbed as an era of " Demographer's Void " in the annals of Chinese social history. This impression sticks to demographers' mind in spite of a large number of efforts to count people by government through censuses, various registration systems, and estimates poured out by individual scholars on varying assumptions. But the resultant figures reveal so many inconsistencies and contradictions that they carry us nowhere. More so, since no comprehensive census report was ever issued during the Kmt. period its population data cannot be subjected to scrutiny which can be applied to the census material of most countries and their value cannot, on that account, be critically assessed.

This is, however, not to deny that it was during this ' formative stage' in the evolution of census consciousness in China that a genuine demographic interest came to be evinced at government level. As the Chief of the Department of Statistics noted

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in his preface to the final report on the data-collecting activities of the period from 1928 to 1930:

> " We have never had an honest investigation of the population. Up to now, the total number is subject to question... Since the basis of the administration of nation relies on household statistics, we therefore issued ' The regulations and forms of household investigation in the fall of 1928 '. Each province was ordered to make an honest investigation, to finish it in a limited time, and to report the results to the Ministry. Thus we hoped to understand whether the state of the nation was prosperous or declining, and whether the population was increasing or decreasing. Furthermore, we hoped to lose the shameful title of " The country without statistics " (1).

With this ambitious visualization to rid China of the shameful title of " country without statistics " directives went from the centre, but without much authority to enforce these on the provinces. Famines and flood, war and pestilence, and to aggravate the headaches of government, civil war with the communists, further broke the backbone of the national economy. In this period of turmoil, the problems reached still deeper which prevented the completion of investigations and made the results poor in quality and quantity.

China of the Kuomintang could't have expected a modern population count on scientific lines. She herself was neither modernized nor scientific; how could her ventures be modern or scientific?

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(1) The same as for f.n. 1, p. 303 of this paper.

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Chinese Equivalents of Terms Used

Ministy of Interior	内政部
Pao Chia	保甲
Taiping	太平
Manchu	滿洲

Chinese Geographical Regions

Anhwei	安徽
Chekiang	浙江
Honan	河南
Hopeh	河北
Hunan	湖南
Hupeh	湖北
Kansu	甘肅
Kiangsi	江西
Kiangsu	江蘇
Kwangsi	广西
Kweichow	貴州
Manchuria	東三省
Shantung	山東
Shansi	山西
Yunnan	云南

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Summary

The paper contains three parts. In the first demographic censuses are analysed and special attention is given to the census issued on 1928; the second part is devoted to the various registrations and investigations executed by the Kuomintang Government; the third part contains an analysis of population estimates by the Government or individual scholars.

Riassunto

Lo studio è diviso in tre parti: 1) analisi dei censimenti demografici con particolare riguardo alle complesse vicende che hanno caratterizzato il censimento del 1928; 2) analisi di varie registrazioni ed inchieste effettuate dal Governo del Kuomintang; 3) analisi di stime della popolazione condotte dal Governo e da privati studiosi.

Résumé

L'étude se subdivise en trois parties: 1) analyse des recensements démographiques eu égard surtout au recensement de 1928; 2) analyse des nombreux enregistrements et enquêtes exécutés par le Gouvernement du Kuomintang; 3) analyse des évaluations de la population effectuées par le Gouvernement et par des privés savants.

Other Publications on China's Population by the Same Author

1. *Population Pressure & War*, AICC Economic Review, Delhi, June 1963.
2. *Population Growth in Mainland China*, Eugenics Review, London, April, 1964.
3. *China's Perennial Census Problem*, Eastern World, London, May, 1964.
4. *Fertility Management and Concern with Overpopulation in Mainland China*, Eugenics Quarterly, New York, September, 1964.
5. *Fertility Control in Communist China* (Editorial), Indian Medical Journal, Cal. Febr, 1965.

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